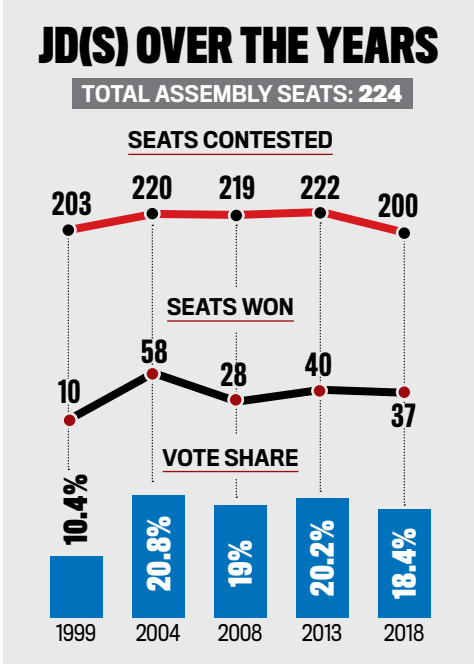


BACK TO BATTLE
H.D. Deve Gowda (right) with H.D. Kumaraswamy (centre), H.D. Revanna (left) and other senior leaders at a JD(S) rally in Mysuru



belongs. In 2018, they accounted for 23 of its 37 seats while the party's footprint across other regions in the state had shrunk. That transition into a caste-based outfit inevitably increased the party's reliance on Gowda's family, so much so that six of its members are currently lawmakers. While Gowda himself is a member of the Rajya Sabha, elder son H.D. Revanna represents Gowda's hometown of Holenarsipura in Hassan district, and Kumaraswamy and his wife Anitha are MLAs from Channapatna and Ramanagara, respectively. Since 2019, Revanna's sons Prajwal and Suraj, too, have embarked on political careers—the former is a Lok Sabha MP from Hassan while the latter is a member of the Legislative Council. Now, Anitha's son Nikhil is replacing her as the candidate for Ramanagara while an open tussle is on for the Hassan assembly seat where Revanna's wife Bhavani wants the party ticket.

All this leaves the party open to accusations, especially from the BJP, of *parivarvaad*. Last year, an angry Kumaraswamy hit back, listing 16 examples of 'family rule' in the state BJP. "They are also living in a glasshouse, but are throwing stones at our party," he told India Today TV recently.

A former two-time CM, Kumaraswamy, 63, has been on the campaign trail since November 18 when he launched the Pancharathna Yatra that has covered 100 constituencies so far. The JD(S), as political observers see it, faces the challenge of retaining